ART ▼

The Means of Defiance

AN EXHIBITION CAPTURES *F.N. SOUZA*'S EXPERIMENTS WITH MAGAZINE PAGES THAT DISSOLVED INTO HAUNTING LANDSCAPES OF HIS UNTAMED IMAGINATION



'Untitled' (1993), depicting felt tip strokes and chemical alteration on magazine paper

There's a consensus that Francis Newton Souza was an outlier, straddling many a paradox throughout his life, including, but not limited to, his overtly stringent Catholic upbringing that barrelled into the primal eroticism of Hindu imagery. Between these contrasting worlds lies the artist's irreverence, which still enthrals, entertain, and even shocks admirers and naysayers alike.

Celebrating this spirit is Kolkata's Emami Art Gallery, with the ongoing exhibition *F.N. Souza: Drawings and Chemical Alterations*, which puts on display his final works (1984 onwards). As the founder of the Bombay Progressive Artists' Group, Souza drew on diverse elements, but did not wish to have a style that married national cultural identity with his modernist art. His restlessness and strong sense of individuality urged British writer and art critic John Berger to once say that Souza "straddled many traditions, but served none". It's this remarkable strain of his work that resonates in the exhibition, especially his experiments with magazine paper, whose chemical alterations he constantly dabbled with. In 1960s New York, he tinkered with the print of paper using a chemical solution which altered its colours and images, enmeshing his sketches and writings in a conversation with the published words and images still visible below the chemically changed surface.

> The show delves into his bond with muse ***Srimati Lal*** via intimate and confrontational portraits

Responding to Berger's observations of the artist, Ushmita Sahu, curator of the exhibition, says that, in 2025, they stand more "prescient" than ever. He was a non-conformist not because of a lack of allegiance, but because it was "a deliberate act of rebellion against artistic servitude". "He absorbed influences as varied as Catholic iconography, European expressionism, Indian folk idioms, and political critique, yet remained accountable only to his own vision," Sahu says.

The show was born out of a quest to rediscover Souza in a less-explored light, which led Saha to some of his rarer works, involving his muse Srimati Lal, journalist, curator and painter, and the artist's closest friend and confidante since the early '90s. "The exhibition makes clear that Lal was far more than a passive muse. She was a mirror, a correspondent and, in many ways, a collaborator. Souza's portraits of her resist idealisation; they oscillate between erotic and devotional, intimate and confrontational," says Sahu. "The archival material and reciprocal portraiture reveal a profound intellectual and emotional intimacy, one grounded in mutual recognition", thereby upholding Souza's untamed spirit reflected, rather fittingly, in a relationship that stood against all norms of its times. ■

—Arshia

The exhibition is on till Oct. 18